

BUSA 3105 – Journal

Journal Entry #1

The quote, “First, we form habits, then they form us. Conquer your bad habits or they will conquer you,” really resonates with me. At the age of 31, I’ve realized that the goals you truly want to achieve and the things that actually benefit and fulfill you require a lot of effort, discipline, and consistency. You must be deliberate in your approach and not expect results without putting in the work. Being productive and reaching goals really comes down to building strong habits over time.

As I’ve gotten older, I’ve become more aware of certain habits that have held me back. One of them is procrastination. I often get too comfortable thinking I have plenty of time, but it always leads to things piling up. “I’ll do it later” ends up turning into rushing to meet deadlines and losing time for other tasks that could have been done earlier. Another habit is not having a consistent daily schedule. Having set time blocks and more structure to my day would help me stay more focused and get things done. A third habit is that I sometimes avoid asking for help even when it would save me time because I don’t like to bother others, but this often slows me down and makes tasks harder than they need to be.

I have developed some habits that help my productivity. One of them is taking notes. I’ve created my own sort of “knowledge base” that I can always go back to. It’s like a second brain, organized in a way that makes sense to me and saves me time from relearning things. Another habit is breaking down tasks systematically before starting them. Even though I struggle with overall planning, once I begin something, I approach it clearly step-by-step which helps me stay on track, especially under pressure. A third helpful habit is active listening during conversations or when I’m learning something. When being mindful about being fully present, I understand things much faster and retain much more of it.

One habit I want to improve to become more productive is reducing procrastination by building a structured daily schedule. To do this, I need to plan every set of the next few days beforehand, setting clear time blocks for specific tasks and following simple rules like starting tasks immediately for a short period to build momentum. By improving this habit, I can avoid the pressure of doing things last minute and give myself more time instead of rushing to complete tasks I should have done earlier.

Journal Entry #2

1. The five adjectives that best describe me are practical, curious, self-aware, analytical, and reflective.
2. By this time next year I will also be described as disciplined, consistent, and driven.
3. I am known for being detail-oriented, following through on my word, and taking things seriously.
4. By this time next year I will also be known for strong time management and being someone others can depend on.
5. My four greatest strengths are problem-solving, attention to detail, persistence, and the ability to learn quickly.
6. My four greatest weaknesses are procrastination, lack of consistent structure, trying to overly perfect things, and overthinking.
7. I feel at my best when I have a clear plan and I am making steady progress on my goals.
8. I feel at my worst when I procrastinate and let things pile up which creates anxiety and leads to rushed work.
9. In the last 90 days I have learned the importance of consistency, building better habits, and staying disciplined instead of relying on motivation.
10. In the next 90 days I hope to learn how to better manage my time, stay consistent with a schedule, and improve my productivity.
11. My personal marketing or “visibility program” consists of building skills through school, working on projects, and positioning myself for opportunities in the tech industry.
12. Important additions to my contacts list or network in the last 90 days include classmates, instructors, and new people with similar goals and mindsets.
13. Important relationships I want to nurture in the next 90 days are with people who are working toward similar goals. I will do it by being more engaged, sharing ideas, and supporting each other’s progress.
14. My principal professional development activity for the past 90 days was focusing on my coursework and improving my technical skills.
15. My principal professional development activity for the next 90 days is building side projects to strengthen my portfolio.
16. In the next year I hope to graduate and secure a role in the tech industry.

This activity was a great exercise for self-reflection. It helped me look at myself from a bird’s-eye view and put things into perspective on where I stand. It showed me what I need to improve and what I’m already doing well. The process of writing everything out made my thoughts clearer and easier to understand. These are things we often think about in our head in the background but putting them down formally makes them easier to act on.

Journal Entry #4

A change that I aspire to make is putting more effort into building relationships at work. I am someone who generally gets along well with people, but in work settings I tend to keep to myself. I am very outgoing and social outside of work and with my friends, but I tend to shift my attitude in professional environments choosing to keep things formal. I usually only build strong relationships with coworkers I am required to directly interact with regularly, rather than making an effort to socialize for the sake of building connections. Sometimes due to a pure focus on the work, I see networking or casual interaction as unnecessary unless there is a clear purpose or existing connection. I have realized now that I often miss opportunities to build valuable connections and feel it makes me less approachable as a team member when I keep to myself.

In order to make this change, I need to be more intentional about starting conversations and being open to building relationships beyond surface level interactions. The cost would be stepping out of my comfort zone and putting in extra effort, but the benefits outweigh these costs. It can lead to more opportunities, better teamwork, a stronger reputation, and greater influence in the workplace. It would also make work a more pleasant experience and help me feel more connected to my work environment. I would recognize and acknowledge small wins to reward myself such as initiating conversations and gradually getting better at doing it consistently over time.

By making it a priority, I believe I can easily improve at this skill. I do not avoid interactions, my focus is simply always on the task at hand while I am performing my job. It is not something I actively think about or view as critical which is why I have not made an effort to do so. I do not have difficulty connecting with others at all, I just need to make a more conscious and consistent effort to engage.

Journal Entry #5

The most ineffective feedback I have received at work was when I was working under a manager with a constantly negative attitude. Even when things were done correctly, he would try to find something bad to say and rarely gave any positive acknowledgment. When there was a mistake, even if it was unintentional and understandable, there was never any grace shown and there was no guidance on how to improve, but he made sure to point the problem out. The manager treated most employees this way, especially newer ones. This created a frustrating environment to work in because there was no clear direction on what needed to change or how to do better moving forward. It made the workplace less enjoyable and lowered my motivation to continue the job long term.

For feedback to be effective, it must have a clear purpose and provide direction on how to improve. Being overly negative when there is no need is counterproductive and not beneficial as it does not help performance improve. The tone and genuine intentions behind the feedback are also important as they influence how it is received and interpreted. If the manager had acknowledged when tasks were completed correctly and provided clear guidance when mistakes were made, it would have created a much better environment. This is why feedback must be constructive in nature so employees understand expectations and know what to improve rather than just scrutinizing them.

The manager's attitude held the entire team back, including himself. He could have achieved much better results, but his approach failed him. As a leader, it is your job to encourage employees to get better and that is achieved through clear feedback that they can build on. When it is absent, it leads to no real progress and continued misalignment.

Journal Entry #6

Regulating self talk and checking your inner voice is critical in maintaining a positive outlook and it fosters better outcomes. I notice that when I do not intentionally remind myself to stay positive, daily challenges become more difficult to complete and I am less willing to devote my energy to them.

I have been experiencing this for the past few months, constantly hearing how AI is making it harder for recent graduates to land a job as junior roles are being cut. It feels stressful and is discouraging after putting significant effort into finally completing my program in a field I genuinely enjoy. My motivation to put in the work for the job search has taken a hit because of this, however, I realize most of this fear is just in my head and is my brain's easy way to find a justification to not do the necessary hard work.

When my inner voice is positive, I am much more productive and eager to tackle challenges. They do not feel overwhelming or like a chore. Lately, I have experienced this with my new workout routine. As someone who struggles with staying consistent, changing my attitude and reminding myself that I am doing what is necessary to be healthy is a great motivator. It is a feeling I want to continuously sustain as I do not want to revert my progress and go back to the feeling of when I was not as dedicated.

Last term's final exam crunch was a time when I was able to change a negative voice to a positive one. I felt under a lot of pressure and anxiety, but reminded myself of the relief I would feel when everything is complete, knowing that I will be one step closer to graduation. I switched my focus to the things I could control which was my preparation. If I took care of that, everything else would fall into place and it gave me enough comfort to not focus on the negative side which put me in a better position to succeed as my attitude improved.

Journal Entry #7

I noticed that when I am listening, I tend to check out most when I feel I have nothing to gain from it. This can be due to multiple reasons such as not being interested in the subject matter or I feel as if I already know all there is to know, therefore, I do not need to listen. Another instance where I struggle to actively listen is when people do not get to the point and draw things out which can make me incredibly impatient.

I am much more engaged when topics of interest to me are being discussed as it is intriguing to see others' viewpoints on things I actually care about and if I can discover new perspectives or information. Additionally, if the individual is an effective and talented communicator, it pulls me in and my attention sustains even further as it adds credibility to the speaker for me.

Communication style is a major factor in how messages are received. To create a positive listening experience, you must keep the listener engaged. It is also a reality that not everyone you encounter will be a good communicator or have the perfect style for you, therefore, showing them some grace is important. As a listener, I could be more patient before mentally checking out even when the message does not immediately capture my attention.

A method that has improved my listening over the past year is paraphrasing. The practice ensures you actively listen so you can relay back what a person is saying accurately in order to make them feel heard and understood. Since I know paraphrasing will improve communication interactions, I make a conscious effort to pay attention to capture what is said as I will essentially have to repeat it.

Journal Entry #8

Engaging with class members throughout this course was an insightful process. I believe this is because the discussion questions require a good amount of self-reflection and it is interesting to see people's perspectives.

One thing I observed is, although everyone has different backgrounds, there are a lot of common themes and relatability between each other's experiences. This means often we face similar challenges in the workplace and by communicating we can learn from another.

The process of giving and receiving feedback in this course taught me that open discussion encourages ideas to be thoughtfully explored in a constructive manner. Feedback is nice to receive as it allows you to see how your message is being interpreted. Often we are stuck in our own way of thinking about things, therefore, feedback can be helpful to determine whether we are on the right track in our understanding and if others agree or disagree. Using feedback to refine your existing understanding is important as it allows you to think of things in a new and more complete way.

One possibly problematic thing I noticed regarding feedback was I tend to respond more to posts I agree or resonate with. I believe it would be valuable to engage more with alternate or unique viewpoints to try and broaden my personal understanding.

I believe giving and receiving regular feedback in the workplace can be incredibly beneficial, however, it should be done through a respectful and productive manner as in this course. By doing this, feedback can be seen as something positive and that leads to growth.

Journal Entry #9

One of the occasions I felt triggered recently was the end of last term. I was facing multiple assignment deadlines right before final exams. When I feel stressed and have a very large workload to get through while under a time crunch, I tend to cut myself off from my normal routine to buckle down and solely focus on the work until it is done. I feel too overwhelmed to think about anything else. Piled up work was the trigger and isolation was my behavioural response. I believe if I could manage my stress better in situations like this and maintain a healthier balance, it would help a lot. Not following my normal routine just adds to the stress and makes me more irritable.

Another time I felt triggered recently was when I was around a group of people being overly negative and making excuses. I pushed back and tried to explain a different perspective, encouraging more self-accountability but it was not received well. People avoiding responsibility and having a negative mindset can be triggering for me. I should have just removed myself from the conversation because a part of me knew they were not willing to listen and change their thinking.

A third time I felt triggered recently was last week when I had plans to hang out with a friend. I expressed to this friend that we must get together on time or I will have to cancel as I am busy with a lot of other things. This friend assured me that we would meet on the agreed upon time and that there is no worry. However, this was not the case. This was very frustrating as I had other responsibilities I could have taken care of in the meantime and felt there was a lack of consideration on their part. I am not sure what I could have done better, but I know I cannot always depend on other people following through as expected so I should just build anticipation for it if it is warranted.

Journal Entry #10

I really enjoyed this course and found that the activities were incredibly useful. I found the discussion and journal assignments were my favorite. Three insights I will take from this course is the importance of leadership styles, ability to adapt and lead change, and lastly the benefits of self-reflection.

By going through this course, I realized the critical part leadership styles play on a team. A single leadership style will not work in every situation. Leaders must be able to recognize the right way to get their team to respond. This requires them to truly understand those they are leading and make adjustments when necessary. Leadership style must be conducive to the environment, personell, and situation in order to be effective. You must be able to view things from outside your own perspective to gain insight. It is not as simple as giving instructions and being rigid, it requires ensuring individuals are adequately supported so they can be productive and are motivated.

Change is hard, therefore, an effective leader must be able to execute when times call for it and position their team to succeed. Change is inevitable so you need to possess the skills to navigate through it by being able to adapt on the fly and lead a team through it. Not everyone reacts the same to change as some are more comfortable, while others need more support throughout the process. To guide your team through the time of uncertainty, leaders must be able to identify any friction to the transition process and mitigate it.

I believe the self=reflection practiced in the course such as these journals is a great way to better get an understanding of yourself and where you stand. Often we are too stuck in our day to day, but taking the time to try and understand your own thoughts and examining them reveals a lot about yourself. Having more awareness of your perceptions and perspectives is incredibly beneficial. It taught me how important it is to slow down and be more thoughtful through a formal process similar to this activity.

Overall, I gained valuable leadership skills from this course and look forward to putting them to use in my career.